The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP

J.D. Vance said that after 21 hours of peace talks in Pakistan **America** and **Iran** had failed to agree a deal. The American delegation quickly headed home on Air Force Two. The vice-president said that America had been “very clear what our red lines are” and that Iran had “chosen not to accept our terms”. Mr Vance suggested that Iran’s nuclear programme proved a particular sticking point: “We need to see an affirmative commitment that they will not seek a nuclear weapon,” he told reporters. Iran’s state news agency blamed America’s “unreasonable demands” for the breakdown in negotiations.

Two American destroyers passed through the **Strait of Hormuz** to begin clearing Iranian-laid mines, the Pentagon said. They were challenged by Iranian forces, which warned them not to proceed, before the American ships departed. Iran denied that any warships had passed through the strait. Meanwhile, three supertankers transited the waterway—a tentative sign that Iran may be easing disruptions to commercial shipping.

Israel’s armed forces say they struck more than 200 targets in **Lebanon** affiliated with Hizbullah, the armed group backed by Iran. Lebanon said at least ten people were killed. Israel’s attacks

will have complicated the peace talks in Islamabad. Iran had demanded the ceasefire with America apply to Israel's operations in Lebanon, too. The Lebanese and Israeli ambassadors in Washington are expected to meet on Tuesday.

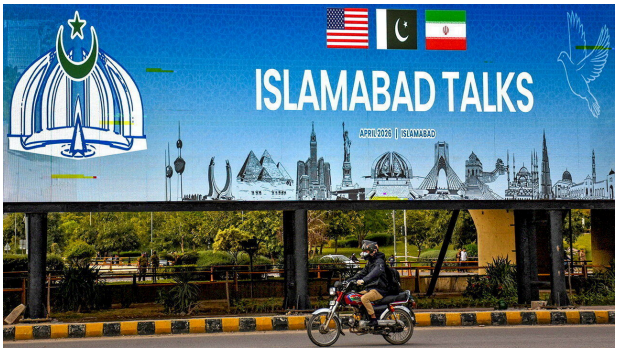
British police arrested more than 500 people during a demonstration opposing the banning of **Palestine Action**. Last year Britain's Labour government proscribed PA as a terrorist organisation, after the pro-Palestine campaign group spray-painted military-leased planes. The High Court later ruled that designation unlawful. In what many see as an affront to free speech, thousands of people have been arrested for holding placards supporting the organisation.

Taiwan's defence ministry said that it spotted 16 Chinese warplanes operating near the island on Friday just as Taiwan's opposition leader, Cheng Li-wun, was meeting **China**'s president, Xi Jinping, in Beijing. A senior Taiwanese official said the sorties showed that China was "sending out messages of peace, while… they continue to use military force to pressure Taiwan."

Sir Keir Starmer, Britain's prime minister, was forced to shelve legislation ceding sovereignty of the **Chagos islands** in the Indian Ocean to Mauritius. Donald Trump had strongly criticised the agreement; the islands include Diego Garcia, home to an American military base. British officials said they were not completely abandoning the plan, but that time had run out to pass it in this session of Parliament.

Japanese prime minister, **Takaichi Sanae**, took a break from political duties to welcome Deep Purple to **Japan**, more than 50 years after the band first toured there. Ms Takaichi's talents as a **heavy-metal drummer** are well documented. She said she had bought the group's album, "Machine Head", while still at school. Meeting Ian Paice, the band's drummer, she told him, "You are my god."

Word of the week: *Boondoggle*, what the International Thermonuclear Experimental Reactor has become. Read the full story.



Photograph: Reuters

Pakistan’s strategic statecraft

As America and Iran failed to strike a deal in Islamabad, Pakistan’s capital, on Sunday, it should not be forgotten that the hosts had plenty riding on a positive outcome too. Denounced by Donald Trump during his first term as a country of only “lies and deceit”, Pakistan’s government has carefully courted America’s president in his second term. It has offered the country as a hub for cryptocurrency and critical minerals, and nominated Mr Trump for the Nobel peace prize. He now calls Asim Munir, Pakistan’s powerful army chief, his “favourite field marshal”.

Pakistan must also maintain a delicate balance with Iran. The countries share a 900km border, which Iranian refugees could spill over if the war restarts. Meanwhile Pakistan depends on the Gulf for its oil and gas, as well as remittances from 5.5m Pakistani workers. But even just hosting the talks was a morale-booster for a country which has suffered floods, insurgencies and soaring inflation, not to mention a war with India.

Photograph: Getty Images

Hungary’s election tests the populist playbook

Hungarians head to the polls on Sunday in what will be Europe’s most consequential election in years. Viktor Orbán has long been the European Union’s most disruptive member, blocking aid to Ukraine and clashing with the bloc over the rule of law. The result will determine whether it regains a more co-operative partner.

After 16 years in power, Mr Orbán’s Fidesz faces its first serious challenge from a unified opposition. Most independent polls suggest the insurgent Tisza party is ahead. But because Mr Orbán has reshaped the electoral system, the opposition must win by a clear margin to take power. In 2022 Fidesz won just over half the vote but more than two-thirds of seats.

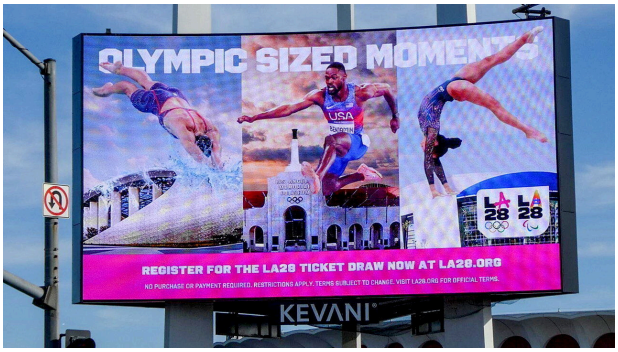
Mr Orbán’s party has become a model for authoritarian movements, showing how to capture the state’s institutions while preserving a semblance of democracy. If he wins, his methods will be vindicated. If he loses, it will signal to strongmen elsewhere that such systems are not unbeatable.

Photograph: AP

Peru’s historically large ballot

A record 35 candidates are competing in Peru’s presidential election, which begins on Sunday amid a surge in crime and corruption. Most polling puts Keiko Fujimori, Peru’s law-and-order contender, in the lead on about 13%—far from the 50% needed to win. Next come Carlos Álvarez, a comedian who wants to introduce the death penalty, and Ricardo Belmont, an octogenarian ex-mayor of Lima who says he will tackle crime with “hugs, not bullets”. Another former mayor of the capital, Rafael López Aliaga, an admirer of Donald Trump, recently fell to fourth place. Many candidates are obscure. Some warn that such a large ballot will confuse voters.

Peru has had nine presidents in the past decade, most of whom were impeached or resigned. A disillusioned and divided electorate makes a run-off almost inevitable—bad news for Ms Fujimori, who has lost the past three. Her detractors joke that she is so unpopular she would lose against a loaf of sweet bread, a local treat.



Photograph: Alamy

Heat is reshaping the Olympics

Tickets for the 2028 Olympic Games in Los Angeles went on sale to the general public this weekend. They are not cheap: seats for popular events already run into the thousands, and even the most affordable “local” tickets cost far more (in real terms) than at the city’s last Games in 1984. But rising prices may not be the biggest concern.

Rising temperatures are. During the 1980s the highest temperature recorded in August was 40.5°C (105°F); the average for the decades was 35.7°C—hot enough to worry athletes even then. Today, such conditions look less exceptional. In March this year, Palm Springs hit 42°C during a severe heatwave.

That does not bode well for 2028. Intense heat raises the risk of dehydration and heat stroke, especially during endurance events. And as climate change pushes temperatures higher, competing in extreme conditions is becoming the norm. The past two Summer Games, in Tokyo and Paris, were both among the hottest on record.

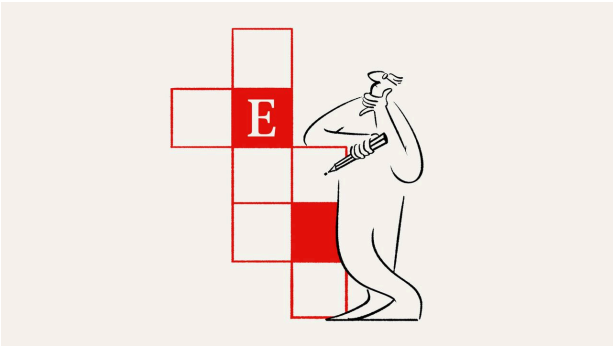


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here. Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Keen to be included in the age requirement (5)

2 across - The Irish expel royal successor (4)

3 across - The night before, not excluding ring ceremony (5)

1 down - Rare is the beguiling appearance of our planet beyond the moon (9)

Straight clues

1 across - Enthusiastic, hankering (5)

2 across - Next in line or beneficiary (4)

3 across - Gathering, occasion (5)

1 down - (Picture of) our home ascending from the horizon of the Moon (9)

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Emilio Ferreira, Buenos Aires, Argentina

Adele & Ted Pelletier, Portland, Oregon

Frank Janssen, Brussels, Belgium

They all gave the correct answers of: Christine Lagarde, the Greens, Carrie Fisher, Salem and The Dead. The theme is Stephen King novels: Christine, The Green Mile, Carrie, 'Salem's Lot and The Dead Zone.

The questions were:

Monday: Who is the President of the European Central Bank?

Tuesday: Which political party won the largest shares of the vote in the recent Baden-Wũrttemburg regional election?

Wednesday: Which actress played Princess Leia in the Star Wars films?

Thursday: In which Massachusetts town did witch trials occur in 1692-93?

Friday: Which short story by James Joyce was the last, and longest, in his Dubliners collection?

The only reason for being a professional writer is that you can’t help it.

Leo Rosten